Phonon Dispersion in a One-Dimensional Multi-atomic Lattice

Solid State Physics — Assignment 1, Question 3

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Abstract

We compute the phonon dispersion of a one-dimensional lattice carrying p atoms of arbitrary mass per unit cell, coupled by nearest-neighbour springs. The equations of motion are reduced by a Bloch ansatz to a $p \times p$ Hermitian eigenvalue problem, which we diagonalise numerically across the first Brillouin zone. The method is validated against the closed-form monatomic and diatomic solutions, reproducing them to 4×10^{-14}. An interactive interface built with Streamlit exposes p, the masses, the spring constant and the lattice constant, and reports the acoustic and optical branches, their frequency limits, the bandgaps between them, and the eigenfrequencies at the zone centre and edge. Three parameter sets demonstrate that the gap is controlled by mass contrast and closes entirely when the masses are equal, while the spring constant sets the overall frequency scale as $\sqrt{K}$ without altering the shape of the spectrum.

1 Introduction

A crystal at finite temperature is not a static array of atoms: each atom oscillates about its equilibrium site, and because the atoms are coupled, those oscillations propagate as waves. The quantised normal modes of these waves are phonons, and the relation $\omega(q)$ between a mode's frequency and its wavevector — the dispersion relation — governs the solid's heat capacity, thermal conductivity and sound velocity.

The one-dimensional chain is the standard setting for this problem because it is exactly solvable and still contains the essential physics. A chain with one atom per cell supports a single *acoustic* branch. Placing p atoms in the cell produces p branches: one acoustic and $p-1$ *optical*. Where the masses differ, a frequency gap opens between them, inside which no travelling wave exists at any wavevector.

This report derives the general p-atom dispersion relation, implements it, validates it against the cases that can be solved by hand, and uses it to examine how masses and spring constants control the spectrum.

2 Theory

2.1 Equations of motion

Consider a chain of identical unit cells of length a. Cell n contains p atoms of masses $m_1, \dots, m_p$. Let u_j^n be the displacement of atom j in cell n from its equilibrium position. Nearest neighbours are joined by springs of constant K, so in the harmonic approximation the force on an atom is linear in the *relative* displacements of its two neighbours:

$$m_j \ddot{u}_j^n = K\left(u_{j+1}^n - u_j^n\right) + K\left(u_{j-1}^n - u_j^n\right). \tag{1}$$

The chain is closed by the identifications $u_{p+1}^n \equiv u_1^{n+1}$ and $u_0^n \equiv u_p^{n-1}$: the last atom of a cell bonds to the first atom of the next. Equation (1) is a coupled system of infinitely many ordinary differential equations, one per atom.

2.2 Bloch ansatz and the dynamical matrix

The system is invariant under translation by a, so by Bloch's theorem the solutions are plane waves modulated by a cell-periodic amplitude. We take

$$u_j^n = \frac{1}{\sqrt{m_j}}\, e_j\, e^{i(qna-\omega t)}, \tag{2}$$

where the factor $m_j^{-1/2}$ is a choice, not a restriction: it makes the resulting matrix Hermitian rather than merely similar to a Hermitian matrix, which is what allows a stable eigensolver to be used below.

Substituting (2) into (1) and cancelling the common exponential turns the infinite system into a finite $p \times p$ eigenvalue problem,

$$D(q)\,\mathbf{e} = \omega^2 \mathbf{e}, \tag{3}$$

with the *mass-weighted dynamical matrix*

$$D_{jj} = \frac{2K}{m_j}, \tag{4}$$

$$D_{j,j+1} = D_{j+1,j} = -\frac{K}{\sqrt{m_j m_{j+1}}}, \qquad j = 1, \dots, p-1, \tag{5}$$

$$D_{1,p} = -\frac{K\, e^{-iqa}}{\sqrt{m_1 m_p}}, \qquad D_{p,1} = D_{1,p}^{*}. \tag{6}$$

Only the inter-cell element (6) depends on q; the phase e^{-iqa} is the Bloch factor picked up on crossing a cell boundary. Since $D(q)^\dagger = D(q)$, its eigenvalues ω^2 are real, and since the harmonic lattice is mechanically stable they are non-negative.

A caution on conventions. Here a is the *full unit-cell length*. Many texts treating the diatomic chain set a to the nearest-neighbour spacing, making the cell $2a$ long; their $\cos(qa)$ is our $\cos(qa/2)$. Mixing the two conventions introduces a silent factor of two into every plotted frequency. All results below use the full-cell convention.

A caution on the $p = 2$ case. When the cell holds exactly two atoms, the intra-cell bond (5) and the inter-cell bond (6) occupy the *same* matrix element: atom 1 bonds to atom 2 twice, once inside the cell and once across the boundary. The two contributions must therefore be added, giving $D_{12} = -K\left(1 + e^{-iqa}\right)/\sqrt{m_1 m_2}$. Overwriting rather than accumulating is an easy implementation error, and it breaks the physics: the acoustic branch no longer vanishes at $q = 0$, violating translational invariance.

2.3 Branch structure

Diagonalising (3) at each q in the first Brillouin zone, $q \in [-\pi/a, \pi/a]$, gives p frequencies. Ordering them ascending at every q:

- the lowest, $\omega_1(q)$, is the **acoustic** branch. It satisfies $\omega_1(0) = 0$, because a uniform translation of the entire crystal costs no energy — this is a direct consequence of $D(0)$ having a null vector $e_j \propto \sqrt{m_j}$. Near $q = 0$ it is linear, $\omega_1 \simeq v_s|q|$, with

$$v_s = a\sqrt{\frac{K}{p\sum_j m_j}}, \tag{7}$$

  obtained by treating the cell as p springs in series over a length a carrying total mass $\sum_j m_j$. This is the speed of sound in the chain.

- the remaining $p - 1$ branches are **optical**. They stay finite as $q \to 0$, where they describe the atoms within a cell oscillating against one another with the cell's centre of mass at rest.

2.4 Closed forms used for validation

For $p = 1$ (mass m) the matrix is 1×1 and

$$\omega(q) = 2\sqrt{\frac{K}{m}}\left|\sin\frac{qa}{2}\right|. \tag{8}$$

For $p = 2$ (masses m_1, m_2) the 2×2 determinant gives

$$\omega_\pm^2 = K\left(\frac{1}{m_1} + \frac{1}{m_2}\right) \pm K\sqrt{\left(\frac{1}{m_1} + \frac{1}{m_2}\right)^2 - \frac{4\sin^2(qa/2)}{m_1 m_2}}, \tag{9}$$

with ω_- acoustic and ω_+ optical. At the zone boundary these reduce to $\omega_- = \sqrt{2K/m_>}$ and $\omega_+ = \sqrt{2K/m_<}$, where $m_>$ and $m_<$ are the larger and smaller mass — so the gap at the zone edge is set purely by the mass contrast and vanishes when $m_1 = m_2$.

3 Numerical method

The procedure is deliberately direct; no iteration or convergence criterion is involved.

1. Build a grid of n_q wavevectors spanning the first Brillouin zone.
2. At each q, assemble $D(q)$ from (4)–(6) as a complex $p \times p$ array, accumulating the inter-cell bond as noted above.
3. Diagonalise with `numpy.linalg.eigvalsh`, the solver for Hermitian matrices. It returns real eigenvalues in ascending order, which is exactly the branch ordering we want, so no sorting step is needed.
4. Take $\omega = \sqrt{\omega^2}$, clipping values at zero first: at $q = 0$ the acoustic eigenvalue is zero up to rounding and can emerge as a small negative number, whose square root would be `nan`.
5. Extract the per-branch minima and maxima, and identify a gap between branches i and $i + 1$ whenever $\min_q \omega_{i+1} > \max_q \omega_i$.

The cost is n_q diagonalisations of a $p \times p$ matrix, negligible for the sizes here, which is why the interface can recompute the full spectrum on every slider movement.

3.1 Validation

Five checks run in `test_phonon.py`; all pass.

Check	What it tests	Result
Diatomic vs Eq. (9)	the general code in the solvable case	4.5×10^{-14}
Monatomic vs Eq. (8)	the $p = 1$ wrap-around branch	1.6×10^{-15}
Zone folding	equal masses in a $3a$ cell unfold onto Eq. (8)	1.4×10^{-4}
Sound velocity	$q \to 0$ slope against Eq. (7)	1.6×10^{-8}
$\omega_1(0) = 0$	translational invariance	0 exactly
Gap closure	equal masses leave no gap	pass

Table 1: Validation results. The first two columns are maximum absolute errors over the zone; the zone-folding figure is limited by the finite q grid, not by the method.

Figure 1 shows the diatomic check graphically: the numerically obtained points lie on the analytic curves everywhere in the zone.

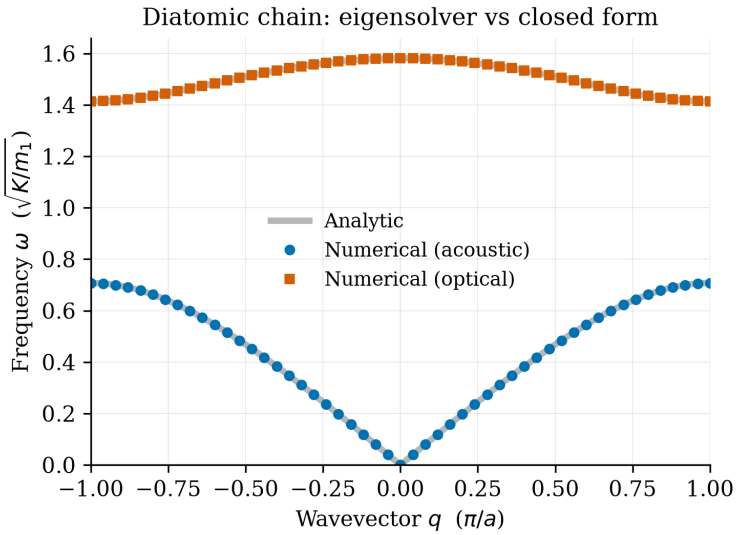


Figure 1: Numerical eigenfrequencies (markers) against the closed-form diatomic solution Eq. (9) (grey), for $m = (1, 4)$, $K = 1$.

4 The interactive interface

The interface is written with Streamlit and launched with `streamlit run app.py`. The sidebar accepts the number of atoms per cell p, one mass field per atom, the spring constant K, the lattice constant a, and the q-grid density; three presets load the demonstration cases below. Every change triggers a recomputation.

The main panel shows the dispersion with the acoustic branch drawn separately from the optical ones, each gap shaded across the zone and annotated with its width, and tables giving the frequency limits of every branch, every bandgap, the analytic sound velocity, and the eigenfrequencies at $q = 0$ and $q = \pi/a$. The density of states is plotted underneath.

5 Results

All results use $K = 1$, $a = 1$ and quote frequencies in units of $\sqrt{K/m_1}$. Three mass/spring combinations are compared.

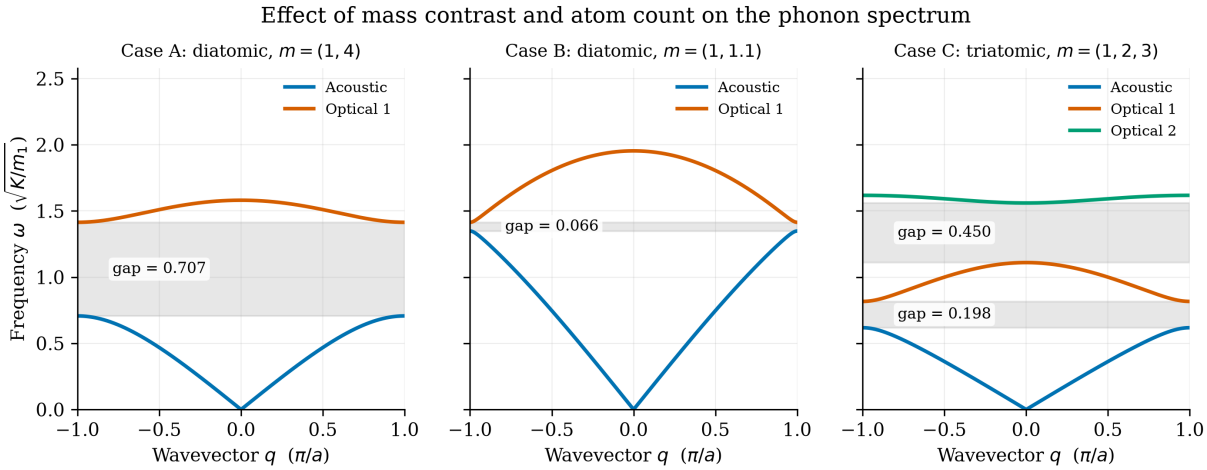


Figure 2: Dispersion for the three cases on a common frequency scale. Shaded bands are forbidden frequency ranges. The acoustic branch starts linearly from the origin in all three.

Case	Masses	Acoustic max	Optical range	Gap(s)	v_s
A	$(1, 4)$	0.7071	1.4142–1.5811	0.7071	0.3162
B	$(1, 1.1)$	1.3484	1.4142–1.9540	0.0658	0.4880
C	$(1, 2, 3)$	0.6180	0.8165–1.1101, 1.5602–1.6180	0.1985, 0.4501	0.2357

Table 2: Computed branch limits, gaps and sound velocities, in units of $\sqrt{K/m_1}$.

5.1 Case A — strong mass contrast

With $m_2/m_1 = 4$ the spectrum splits cleanly. The acoustic branch tops out at $\omega = 0.7071 = \sqrt{2K/m_2}$ and the optical branch bottoms at $\omega = 1.4142 = \sqrt{2K/m_1}$, both at the zone boundary and both matching the analytic zone-edge values exactly. The gap of 0.7071 is wide — it spans half the entire frequency range of the crystal. Physically, at the zone edge the two sublattices decouple: in the acoustic mode only the heavy atoms move appreciably, in the optical mode only the light ones, so each frequency is that of a single mass on its springs.

5.2 Case B — near-equal masses

Raising m_2 by only 10% above m_1 leaves a gap of 0.0658, barely a tenth of Case A's. The two branches very nearly join at the zone boundary, and the spectrum approaches the single folded branch of a monatomic chain. This is the diagnostic case: the gap is a consequence of the *two-member basis*, and it closes continuously as that basis becomes trivial, rather than being an independent property of the lattice. Figure 3 traces this directly.

5.3 Case C — three atoms per cell

With $p = 3$ there are one acoustic and two optical branches, and correspondingly two gaps, 0.1985 and 0.4501. The general rule is visible here: p atoms per cell give p branches and up to $p - 1$

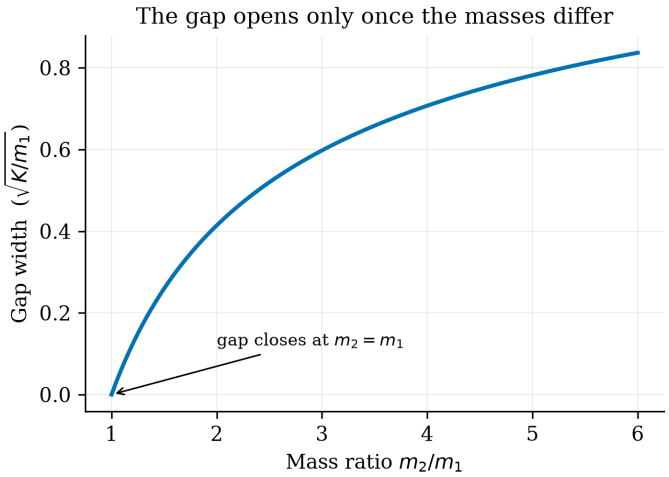


Figure 3: Gap width against mass ratio for a diatomic chain. The gap grows monotonically from zero at $m_2 = m_1$; there is no threshold ratio below which a gap fails to appear.

gaps. The upper optical branch is noticeably flat, varying only between 1.5602 and 1.6180 across the whole zone. A flat branch means a near-zero group velocity $\partial\omega/\partial q$: those modes carry almost no energy through the crystal, and they appear in the density of states as a sharp peak.

5.4 Effect of the spring constant

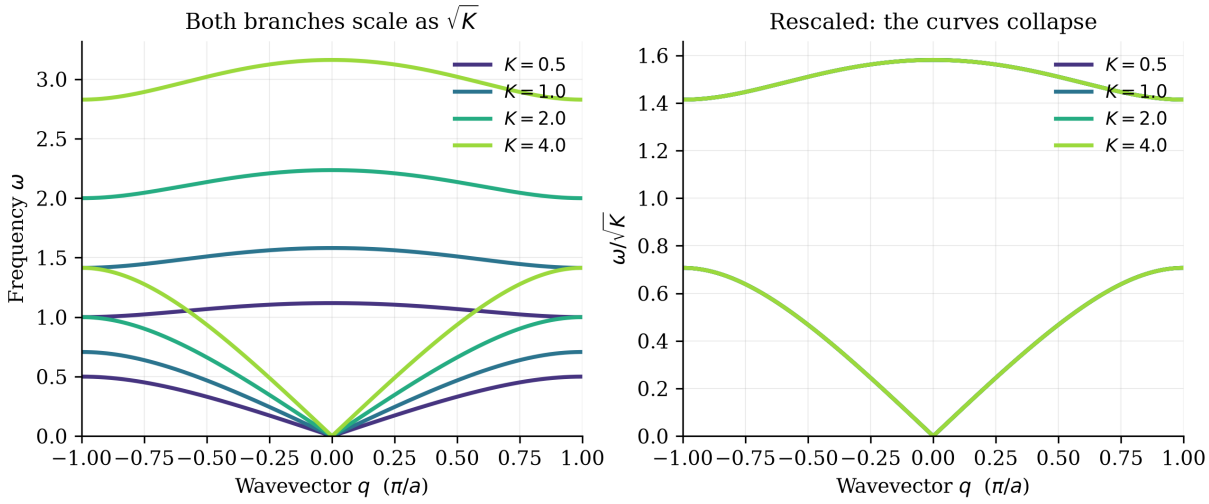


Figure 4: Left: Case A dispersion at four spring constants. Right: the same curves divided by $\sqrt{K}$, collapsing onto a single pair.

The spring constant enters (4)–(6) as an overall multiplier, so $D(q) \propto K$ and therefore $\omega \propto \sqrt{K}$ at every q. Figure 4 confirms this: rescaling by $\sqrt{K}$ collapses all four spectra onto one curve. Stiffer springs raise every frequency, including the gap width in absolute terms, but leave the *shape* of the spectrum — and hence all ratios, including gap-to-bandwidth — untouched. Mass contrast and spring constant therefore play different roles: masses set the structure of the spectrum, K sets only its scale.

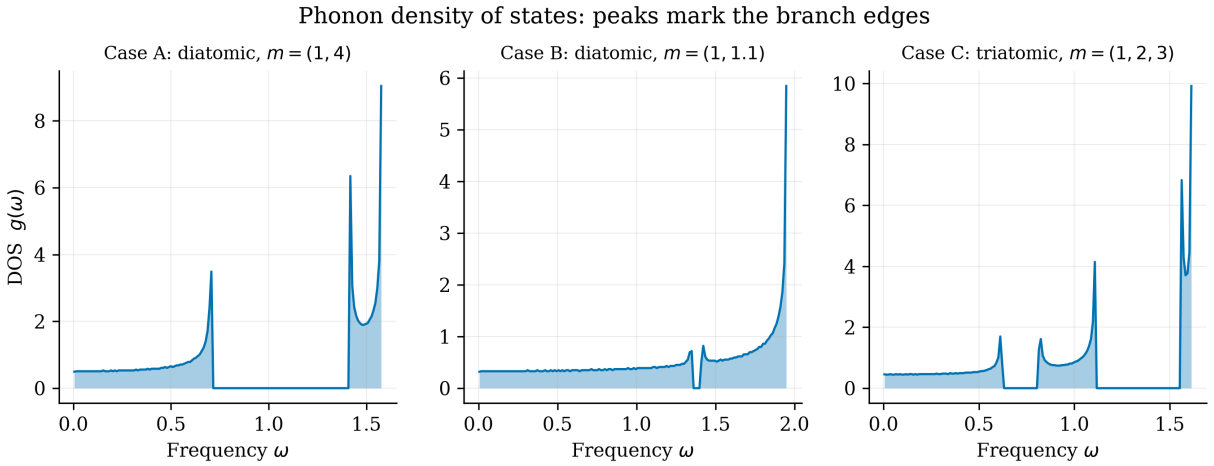


Figure 5: Phonon density of states for the three cases, from a histogram of ω over a dense q mesh. Empty regions are the bandgaps of Table 2.

5.5 Density of states

The density of states $g(\omega)$ counts modes per unit frequency. It is zero inside every gap, which is what "forbidden frequency range" means in practice: an incident wave at such a frequency finds no mode to propagate in and is reflected. The sharp peaks are van Hove singularities, occurring where a branch has zero slope — at the zone centre and boundary, and across the whole of a flat branch. Case C's flat upper optical branch produces the most pronounced peak of the three, exactly as its shape in Figure 2 predicts.

5.6 Eigenfrequencies and their significance

Case	**Branch**	ω at $q = 0$	ω at $q = \pi/a$
A	Acoustic	0.0000	0.7071
	Optical 1	1.5811	1.4142
B	Acoustic	0.0000	1.3484
	Optical 1	1.9540	1.4142
C	Acoustic	0.0000	0.6180
	Optical 1	1.1101	0.8165
	Optical 2	1.5602	1.6180

Table 3: Eigenfrequencies at the zone centre and zone boundary.

The eigenfrequencies are the natural frequencies of the lattice: a mode excited at $\omega_i(q)$ oscillates indefinitely at that frequency in the harmonic approximation, and any arbitrary motion of the chain decomposes into a superposition of them. Table 3 shows the two limiting cases.

At $q = 0$ all cells move identically. The acoustic eigenvalue is exactly zero in every case, since translating the whole crystal stretches no spring. The optical frequencies there are nonzero because the atoms inside a cell move against each other — for Case A, $1.5811 = \sqrt{2K(1/m_1 + 1/m_2)}$, the frequency of two masses vibrating on a shared spring about their common centre of mass. This is the mode that couples to infrared light in a real ionic crystal, and the origin of the name "optical".

At $q = \pi/a$ adjacent cells move in antiphase, the shortest wavelength the lattice supports. Both branches flatten here, which is why the gap edges in Table 2 are attained at the boundary.

6 Conclusions

Reducing the chain's equations of motion to a $p \times p$ Hermitian eigenvalue problem gives a method that handles any number of atoms per cell with no change of algorithm, and reproduces the textbook monatomic and diatomic solutions to within 10^{-13}. Applying it:

- p atoms per unit cell give one acoustic and $p-1$ optical branches, with up to $p-1$ gaps between them.
- The bandgap is produced by mass contrast within the cell and closes continuously as the masses are equalised — 0.7071 at a mass ratio of 4, 0.0658 at a ratio of 1.1, zero at 1.
- The spring constant scales all frequencies as $\sqrt{K}$ and changes nothing else about the spectrum.
- Flat branches produce van Hove peaks in the density of states and carry negligible group velocity.

The obvious limitations are the harmonic approximation, which excludes thermal expansion and phonon lifetimes, and the restriction to nearest-neighbour coupling in one dimension.

7 Contributions

Part	Members
Derivation of the equations of motion and dispersion relation	
Implementation of the dynamical matrix and eigensolver	
Validation against analytic limits	
Interactive interface	
Figures, parameter studies and interpretation	
Report preparation and references	

Table 4: To be completed before submission.

Reproducing this work

```
uv venv --python 3.12 .venv
uv pip install numpy scipy matplotlib streamlit pandas
cd question_3
python test_phonon.py     # validation checks
python make_figures.py    # regenerates every figure
streamlit run app.py      # interactive interface
```

References

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[4] D. Tong, *Lectures on Solid State Physics*, University of Cambridge. https://www.damtp.cam.ac.uk/user/tong/aqm.html

[5] C. R. Harris *et al.*, "Array programming with NumPy", *Nature* **585**, 357–362 (2020). `numpy.linalg.eigvalsh` documentation.

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